Didot is a historical typeface with origins in technological innovation.

Didot is still in use and is associated with high fashion and high-end culture.

The co-existence of tradition and technology

The changing nature of what we identify as “high” culture

The use of the centered axis to signify tradition and classical typography

The use of the modular grid to signify modern or contemporary culture

The collision of these two worlds into a third thing that is both “beautiful” and challenges traditional notions of beauty

now that's a

fation

FACE

or

The

EMPIRICAL ELEGANCE

of Didot

for the rashional designer.

DIDOT,

designed by Firmin Didot around 1783, is a font that signified a revolution in typefaced design. In its rational, geometric structure, it marked a distinct break from the calligraphy-based typefaces that preceded it. Firmin Didot was born to a family of printers and publishers who had added type founding to their business. The Didot family was active in printing and type founding throughout most of the 18th and 19th centuries in Paris. All seven members of his family were engaged in this business, which was founded by Firmin's grandfather Francois Didot in 1713. The family, as printers to Charles IX, were arguably the most important print shop and foundry in 18th century France.

Firmin served as the punch-cutter and began designing type by reworking his father's Roman alphabets into what becomes known as the "modern" style. Over the course of the next decade,

HE CONTINUES TO DEVELOP HIGHER-CONTRAST AND MORE DARING FONTS.

THE NEW FONT HE DESIGNED FOR THE *Virgil* AND THE *Louvre Editions* OF 1798 ARE GENERALLY THOUGHT TO MARK THE PINNACLE OF HIS WORK AS A TYPE DESIGNER. IN 1814 HE WAS MADE DIRECTOR OF THE NATIONAL TYPE FOUNDRY BY NAPOLEON BONAPARTE.

Though typically characterized as a "modern" face (or Didone, according to the Vox-ATypI system),

DIDOT IS PERHAPS BETTER UNDERSTOOD AS A

NEO—

CLASSICAL typeface, as proposed by Robert Bringhurst. Bringhurst advocates a wholistic system of classification in which categories are based on the larger historical context instead of similar formal properties among faces.

This system contextualizes type design within larger artistic, philosophical, and cultural movements in the West.

UNLIKE TRADITIONAL TYPEFACES, WHOSE WEIGHT MODULATIONS WERE BASED ON THE MOVEMENT OF THE BROAD-NIB PEN, THE MODERN TYPEFACE IS CHARACTERIZED BY

extreme contrast between thick and thin strokes,

hairline serifs with minimal bracketing,

a small x-height,

and

the heaviest weight being placed on the vertical part of rounded strokes.

THE CONTRAST MAKES THE DIDOT so pretty BUT so hard to kern.

THE RESULT IS A TYPEFACE BUILT WITH A FEELING OF

OPTICAL AND MECHANICAL CONSISTENCY.

This is most notable in the intense vertical axis, which is made more pronounced by extreme contrast to hairline horizontal strokes. Even in curved strokes of the letters e,o, and c, the thin stroke falls horizontally, perpendicular to the baseline.

These designs were made feasible for use by technological innovations: the advent of steel and copper engraving that allowed for greater technical precision, and the development of wove paper that provided a superior printing surface for the hairline weights of the new typeface.

A contemporary of Firmin Didot, Gianbiattista Bodoni, one of the premier Italian printers of the time, designed a bolder and more radical modern typeface with greater contrast between thicks and thins and unbracketed hairline serifs. It represented a further departure from traditional typefaces—far enough that they were considered to be of a recognizably different genus. Though Didot is considered by many to be a finer and more nuanced design, it can be argued that Bodoni is more widely accepted and recognized as the quintessential modern face.

While Didot was recognized as the preeminent typographer in France, Bodoni had a larger international reputation and was able to cut many variations of his typeface, which were disseminated throughout Europe. Through Didot is more gracile, it is Bodoni that is more commonly associated with fashion and elegance.

DIDOT WAS BROUGHT INTO

VOGUE BAZAAR

in the 20th century by Alexei Brodovich, who was then art director for HARPER'S

Perhaps because of the feeling of slenderness

CREATED BY ITS EXAGGERATED VERTICAL STROKES AND DELICATE HAIRLINES, ITS ASSOCIATION WITH

Frenchness

OR PERHAPS FOR NO OTHER REASON THAN ITS ASSOCIATION WITH BAZAAR, DIDOT IS

a signifier for HIGH FASHION

(though many mistake Bodoni for the typeface used in *Bazaar*).

After a short-lived change to a heavy sans serif masthead, Johnathan Hoefler was commissioned by the magazine's new director to design a version of Didot for the magazine's masthead. The first digital version of Didot was designed by Adrian Frutiger in 1992 based fonts cut by Firmin Didot between 1799 and 1811.

Though based on Bodoni and not Didot, my favorite interpretation of the modern face is Zuzana Licko's Filosofia–partly because it reads well as a text face, but mostly because of the quirkiness of the unicase face. The idea of applying the utopian ideals of efficiency and uni-

versality that a unicase font carries to a Bodoni revival is a smart way to breathe new life into the font by inventing within the lexicon of modern ideas, rather than stopping at a formal historical revival.

I particularly love the fact that she took the archetypal "fashion font" and gleaned from it the odd beauty and playfulness of Filosofia unicase.

I find Didot more interesting for the formal and structural innovations and problems the design presents than as a typeface *per se*. The high contrast between weights and horizontal tension creates a dynamic line of type, but it's not the easiest typeface to read at length. And as much as it has been used as a symbol of elegance and refinement, it has also been abused by design ideologues who consider it part of their typographic pantheon. But, in my estimation, the fact that Didot's modern type still resonates with formal connotation and inspires designers after three centuries is testament enough to its merits.

Didot regular

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